

» PARIS OLYMPICS
BOXING

Forgettable display: Indian boxers' below-par performance in Paris raised several pointed questions for the BFI to answer. RITU RAJ KONWAR

A DEVASTATING PUNCH IN THE GUT

It's time for introspection and brainstorming for the Boxing Federation of India (BFI) after the country drew a blank in the Paris Olympics, despite fielding a **solid team** that included two World champions and as many Worlds medallists.

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If Lovlina Borgohain's bronze in the 69kg category in Tokyo ended a medal drought from the previous two Games, the Indian boxers' below-par performance in Paris raised several pointed questions for the BFI to answer.

The campaign went off-track during the qualification phase itself. After securing four women's quota places in the Asian Games, India

could not achieve a single slot in the first World Olympic qualifying event in Busto Arsizio.

The exit of Irish high-performance director Bernard Dunne was a distraction, but the remaining coaching staff, including foreign coach Dmitri Dmitruk, who was brought into the system by Dunne, tweaked the training method — from short-duration sessions to giving additional time for boxers to work on their game individually — to put the preparation back on track.

Following some changes in the team, India managed to secure three more quota places, including reclaiming the 57kg spot that the country had lost following Parveen Hooda's whereabouts failure, in the second World qualifier in Bangkok.

The BFI, with backing from the Sports Authority of India (SAI), provided all sorts of support, including hiring a psychologist and a chef (to serve Indian food to the boxers) and sending the boxers for training camps abroad during the preparatory phase.